

“Sometimes You Have to Take a Loss to Gain”: Navigating the Tension Between Restricting and Embracing Generative AI

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Abstract

Generative AI has pushed educators at every level to reconsider long-standing practices about learning and assessment. Online communities such as Reddit have become spaces where educators navigate these changes together, sharing their experiences and strategies around AI in academia. In this study, we conducted a qualitative analysis of 45 AI-related discussion threads from r/Professors and r/Teachers, two major subreddits for educators. We identified five emerging practices educators use in response to AI: Restrict (remove AI from assessment), Detect and Enforce (catch and penalize AI use), Redesign (make AI fail), Reframe (change what gets graded), and Embrace (teach responsible use). Our analysis highlights the trade-offs educators make in carrying out these practices and offers insights to support them in the rapidly changing landscape of AI in academia.

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1 Introduction & Background

The adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) in education has risen rapidly in recent years. These tools have evolved considerably in their capabilities and can now support complex academic tasks. Their widespread adoption and growing capabilities are reshaping academia, raising concerns about their impact on learning while also driving changes in teaching practices.

Recent research has made substantial efforts to understand the risks posed by AI in education and to examine stakeholders’ concerns from different perspectives. Through a survey and interview study, Adnin et al. examined students’ undisclosed use of AI and found that educators were concerned about its negative impact on students’ learning outcomes [1]. In a literature review, Buele et al. found that, beyond student outcomes, much of the discussion is now shifting toward how to teach and assess learning effectively in this new environment [2]. Other studies have used social media discourse to understand the perspectives and experiences of different stakeholders. Wu et al. analyzed discussions among students and

educators in education-related subreddits and found increasingly negative sentiment toward Generative AI (GenAI) in education [6]. They identified student and educator experiences centered on academic integrity concerns, perceived threats to traditional educational values, and the tension and burden that adoption and controlled use place on stakeholders. In a similar study of Reddit posts and comments from students, educators, and parents, Kumarage et al. found that GenAI discourse in education centers more on practical use and sensemaking than on institutional concerns such as academic integrity [5]. They also observed role-based differences across groups: students experiment, parents seek utility, and educators weigh pedagogy against accountability, pointing to a “negotiated normalization” of GenAI in educational practice.

While these studies examined perspectives across multiple stakeholders, a deep understanding of how AI is reshaping educators’ work, experiences, and practices is still missing. We complement prior work by analyzing the experiences educators encounter in their work, the emerging practices they use to navigate AI adoption in academia, and the challenges they face in doing so. To achieve this, we analyze organic, unfiltered, and spontaneous conversations among educators in two subreddits: r/Professors and r/Teachers, where educators seek advice and share experiences with their peers. Because these discussions unfold naturally among practitioners, they offer an authentic view of how educators are experiencing and responding to AI in their everyday work.

2 Method

We used Arctic Shift [3] to download all posts and comments from r/Professors and r/Teachers from January 2025 to May 2026, excluding posts deleted by the original poster, moderators, or Reddit. We then filtered the posts using a list of keywords relating to AI (including AI, artificial intelligence, generative AI, GAI, GenAI, large language model, LLM, Gemini, GPT, ChatGPT, Claude, etc.), i.e., the title or the post needs to contain at least one of the keywords. Matching was case-insensitive and performed at the word level to avoid false matches (e.g., “ai” in “thai”), yielding 3,094 posts. We randomly sampled posts from this dataset and a researcher manually reviewed each one, replacing it if it was not relevant to the study.

We conducted an inductive coding process to analyze the threads (a thread consists of a post and subsequent comments and replies). Three researchers first coded 15 threads over multiple rounds, meeting regularly to discuss codes, clarify definitions, resolve disagreements, and establish an initial codebook. Two researchers then coded the same sets of 5–10 threads, meeting after each set to compare codes and resolve disagreements. After 35 threads, inter-coder agreement reached a Brennan and Prediger kappa of 0.79,



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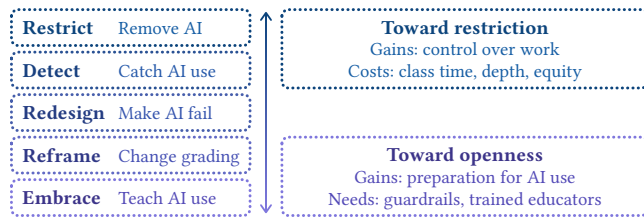


Figure 1: Practices in response to generative AI.

indicating substantial agreement [4]. The researchers then coded independently in sets of 5–10 threads, meeting between sets to discuss uncertainties and emerging codes. To date, we have coded 45 relevant threads (2,793 comments). We conducted a thematic analysis by repeatedly revisiting these threads and codes to identify common themes, a subset of which is presented in this poster. Although this content is publicly available, we took steps to protect Reddit users’ privacy: we paraphrased all quotations to make specific comments and commenters harder to re-identify.

3 Results

We have identified a spectrum of emerging practices among educators from restricting AI to embracing it (Figure 1), discussed below.

Restrict (remove AI from assessment): The most common strategy was a return to handwritten, in-person work in both K-12 and higher education – blue books, in-class essays and drafts in place of take-home papers, and oral exams. In the digital domain, educators restrict usage through lockdown browsers, webcams, proctoring, network blocking, and zero-tolerance policies.

Detect and enforce (catch and penalize AI use): Many educators try to catch AI use after submission. They compare work against in-class baselines, flag mismatches such as near-perfect homework finished in minutes, check citations for fabricated sources, run oral follow-ups, and use detectors as flags before reporting suspected cases to administrators. However, detectors return inconsistent results and disproportionately flag formal academic writing and work by English as a Second Language (ESL) and autistic students. Reporting is burdensome, administrators rarely act, and policing adds to educators’ workload. As one educator wrote, “*You end up in a gray area where it feels like AI, but you can’t prove it.*”

Redesign (make AI fail): Many educators design assessments so that AI-generated work costs more effort than it saves, or cannot supply the required evidence. Their rubrics penalize typical AI weaknesses like surface-level analysis, hallucinated information, imprecise citations, etc. Tasks are designed around material AI does not have, such as class discussions, non-public materials, and local cases. Educators require drafts, annotations, tracked documents, and source trails showing that each source exists and says what the paper claims.

Reframe (change what gets graded): A key strategy was to grade only what educators can observe, such as in-class writing, oral explanations, and participation. One educator wrote that credit should come from “*...what you can do in class,*” because otherwise “*...we’re rewarding the best prompters.*” Educators also shifted weight from unsupervised work to supervised exams, set minimum exam

scores for passing, stopped grading homework to remove the incentive to cheat, and adopted oral defenses and authenticity rubrics.

Embrace (teach responsible use): Several educators argue that students will use AI regardless and that, like calculators and the Internet, it will become part of everyday work. They allow AI with disclosure, asking students to cite it, explain its use, or log prompts and outputs. They teach AI literacy by having students critique AI outputs, check sources, and discuss AI openly. Their central message is that AI should help with the work, not do it.

4 Discussion and Limitations

All five practices reflect a common tension between moving toward restriction and moving toward openness. Moving toward restriction prioritizes accountability, giving educators control over how the work is produced. That control takes class time, assignment depth, and educators’ time. It also depends on infrastructure and enforcement that institutions must provide, and raises equity concerns, e.g., handwritten work can conflict with accommodations, and detectors misflag ESL and autistic students. Conversely, moving toward openness prioritizes preparing students for an AI-normalized world. It depends on several guardrails and training, such as gaining foundational skills first, and on educators who understand responsible use. Educators’ preparation, however, is not uniform. We observe that educators are moving toward redesigning assessment to balance restriction and openness. However, several redesign strategies rely on AI weaknesses that may not hold as AI capabilities evolve, making the situation an ongoing arms race for educators.

Most educators combine practices rather than committing to one; one educator had students write their first lab report by hand, then type it without the help of AI, and only then taught them to use AI in their workflow. Institutional guidance, often framed as a single ban-or-allow policy, does not match this practice. Instead, institutions should support both directions: infrastructure and enforcement for restriction, and guardrails and training for openness.

Our analysis draws on 45 threads from two subreddits, and Reddit users may not represent all educators. These results offer only a glimpse of our preliminary findings from ongoing coding, and in future work we plan to expand our analysis to other pedagogical and institutional aspects.

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